

WHAT IS THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN RIGHT AND WRONG?

Take a look at the list below. You've probably committed at least one or two of these "crimes" yourself, some of them more than once. It's more than likely you knew at the time that it was wrong to do so and you also recognize that some of these misdeeds are more serious than others. How did you come to know the difference between right and wrong behavior and why is it so important?

PATH OF RIGHTEOUSNESS

HAVE YOU EVER DONE ANY OF THE FOLLOWING?

- pushed ahead of someone in a line
- cheated on a test
- told a story about a friend that you knew was not true
- got into an argument at school
- kept the money when a salesperson handed you too much change
- lied about why you didn't do your homework

GUILTY CONSCIENCE

You know that voice inside your head that nags you when you've done something wrong? Of course, it's not a real voice—another word for it is your conscience. Ignore your conscience at your peril. It has a nasty habit of catching you unaware, leaving you red-faced and stammering, "Sorry, teacher, I didn't mean to break the window." Naughty, naughty!

PLAYGROUND RULES

You were not born with a conscience—it comes with experience. Babies and toddlers have no moral sense of what is right and wrong, so they have to be taught not to grab one another's toys. At school, you soon learn what type of behavior is acceptable in the playground and what is not. It can be tough if you love rough games, but everyone has to observe the rules.

PRAISE OR BLAME

There are two ways of teaching morality—the difference between right and wrong. You can praise someone when they do something right. This will make them feel so pleased with themselves that they'll want to repeat their good behavior. Alternatively, you can tell them off when they do something wrong and punish them so that they know not to make the same mistake again—or that's the idea.